

Switching off to tune in

All of us have our travel bucket list and some places sit on it for years. Every book you read, every documentary you watch, and every story you hear inspires you to visit that country someday. Japan was one such place for me. So, when I finally landed in Yokohama, a city that blends futuristic innovation with deep-rooted traditions, I knew I was in for an experience that would leave a lasting impact. While the neon-lit streets, efficient public transport, and the omnipresence of vending machines fascinated me, it was something far simpler that truly inspired me: Japan's culture of solo dining.

I noticed one such diner while walking through the streets of Yokohama. And, while I had read about this in the past, just the focus with which people were eating was still fascinating. And, also odd at first. In many cultures, including India, meals are inherently social activities. We gather around the dining table with family, catch up with friends over lunch, and even extend business meetings over dinner. Eating is often accompanied by chatter, laughter, and more recently the glare of a smartphone screen.

But in Japan, I found an entirely different approach. Many restaurants, especially ramen shops and conveyor belt sushi spots, are designed for individual diners. It's not just accepted...it's celebrated.

The entire experience is about mindfulness. It gives you an opportunity to focus on the taste, the texture, the aroma and in these moments there is no rush, no distractions and no endless scrolling through social media. It's just you and your meal. It made me realise how, in India, we treat meals as just another multitasking opportunity.

In India, it's common to see families gathered around the television while eating. Even more concerning is the sight of young children glued to YouTube videos during mealtimes. I have seen parents promote this too. While I am no one to school them, it only causes further addiction among kids, making them dependent on screens.



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Manas Tiwari
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What was once a moment for bonding or mindful consumption has now turned into an extension of our digital dependency. I've lost count of the number of times I've seen people scrolling through their phones at restaurants, barely engaging with their food, let alone their dining companions. It's a habit that seems harmless, but the implications are far-reaching. While our addiction to screens during meals has reduced our attention span, it often leads to overeating because we fail to register how much we've consumed. As someone who also loves to cook and serve, these practices also take away the simple joy of serving the meal. We've become so accustomed to constant stimulation that even a basic activity like eating feels incomplete without some digital accompaniment.

This trip to Japan reminded me of the importance of disconnecting. Imagine what would happen if we adopted Japan's solo dining philosophy, even in small ways. What if we took a break from our devices at meal-times, whether eating alone or with family? What if we used that time to simply enjoy our food, observe our surroundings, or engage in meaningful conversations? What if we allowed ourselves a few pockets of digital silence every day, where we weren't consuming content but simply existing in the moment?

This isn't about rejecting technology. It's about using it more intentionally. We live in an era where digital connectivity is inevitable, and often necessary, but we need to carve out spaces where we can unplug. It could start with something as simple as putting our phones away during meals, taking a walk without earbuds, or even sitting quietly with a cup of coffee without reaching for a screen.

What Japan taught me was that in the stillness of those quiet meals, there was a kind of freedom, a rare and precious clarity that reminded me of how little we actually need to feel present and fulfilled. And perhaps that's something worth embracing, no matter where in the world we are. ■



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